

The background of the slide is a painting of a vast desert landscape under a clear blue sky. In the distance, two large pyramids stand on the horizon. A caravan of people riding camels is visible in the middle ground, moving across the sand dunes. In the foreground, a person with red hair, wearing a blue dress and a dark backpack, is seen from behind, walking away from the viewer. The bottom half of the image is overlaid with a dark grey semi-transparent band containing the title and subtitle.

What Does It Take to Be Wise?

Moving beyond alarm and governance in the Christian AI conversation

Rachel Wondergem · Wisdom in the Age of AI · Calvin University · October 8, 2026



Egypt, 1989. Exhibit A: the perm.



ONE-DAY TREK: GIZA TO SAQQARA, 1989



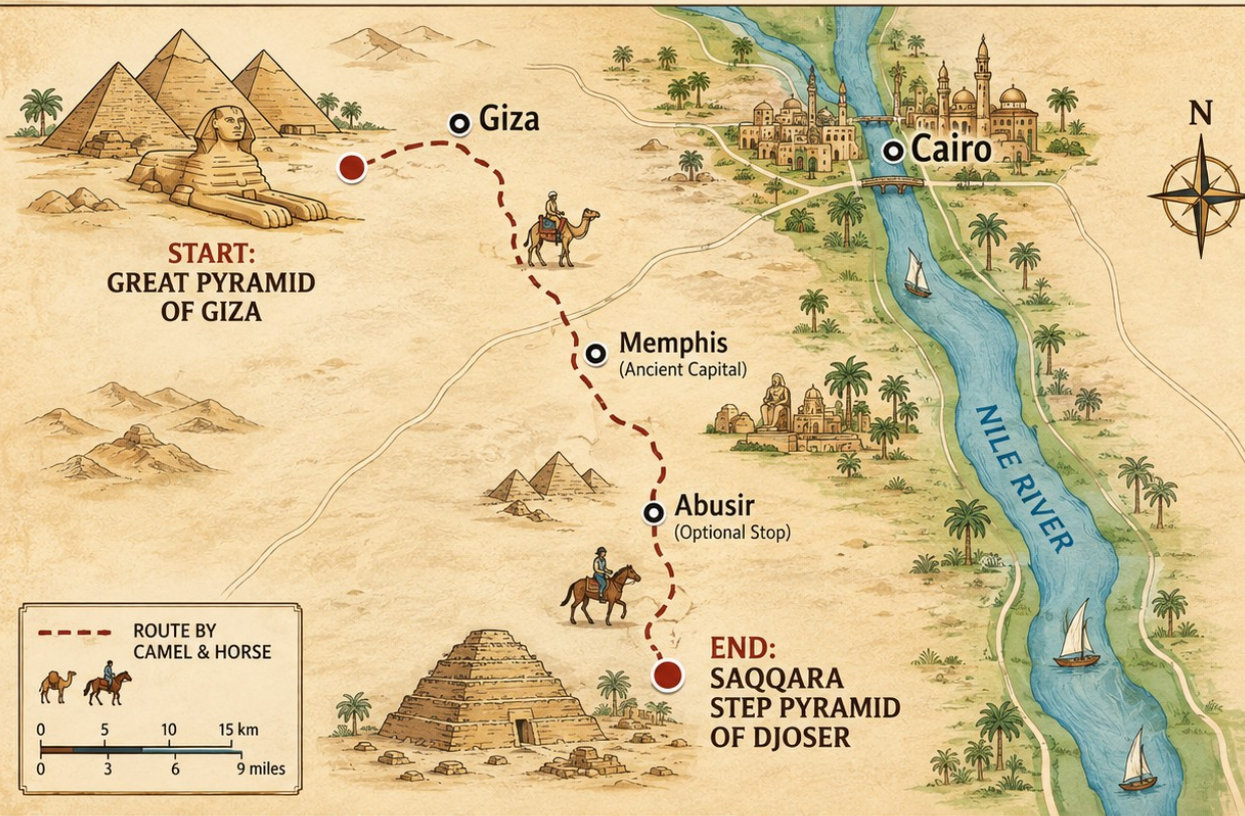
CAMEL & HORSE
JOURNEY



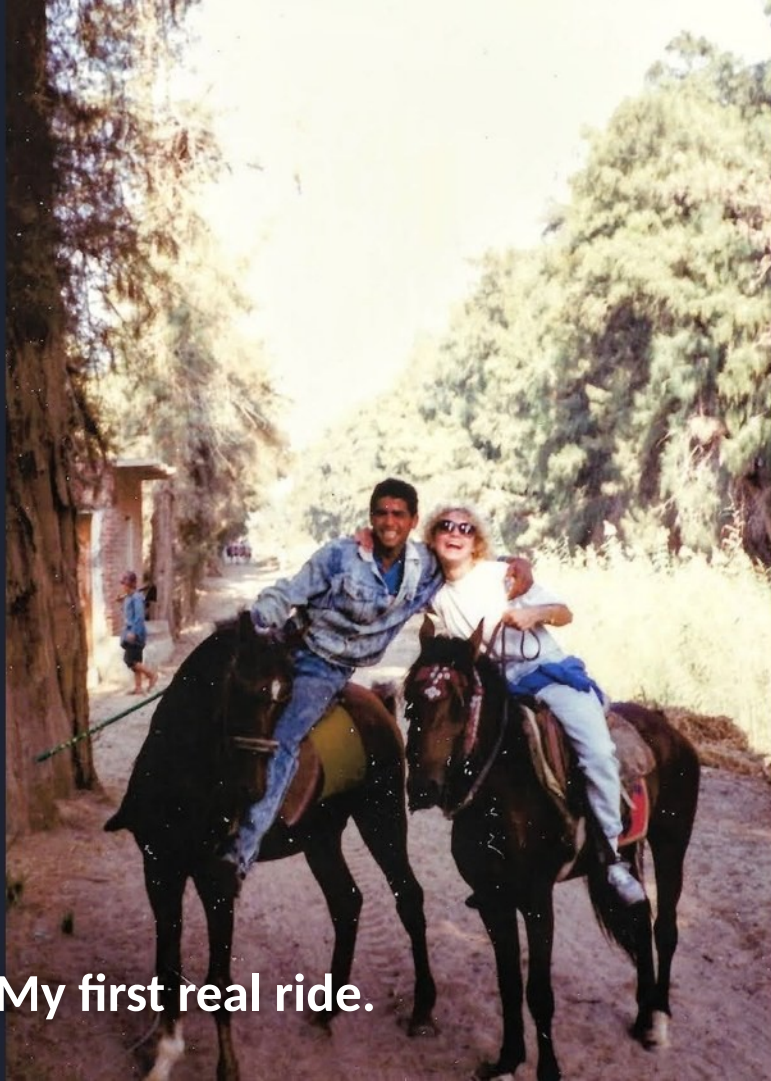
APPROX.
25 KM
(15.5 MILES)



ONE LONG DAY
TREK IN 1989



My guide. My horse. My first real ride.





Over the dune.

My horse was already responding to the world
that had arrived.

I was still riding through the world I expected.

Which one of us acted more wisely?

Not: can a machine be wise?

**What does it take for any agent to act
wisely?**

Ma'at

the order woven into the world at its making — the way things are meant to fit together

To live wisely was to live in alignment with the order of things.

The traditions accumulate

- **Egypt** Ma'at — living in alignment with the order of things
- **Hebrew scriptures** skillful living, in right relationship with God, creation, and neighbor
- **The Greeks** living in accord with the rational order woven through the world
- **Buddhist traditions** seeing reality clearly enough to live free of illusion
- **Confucian thought** knowing what is right within relationships, and acting with care

reality has an order · we have a place in it · wisdom is perceiving it truly and acting in alignment with it

Wisdom

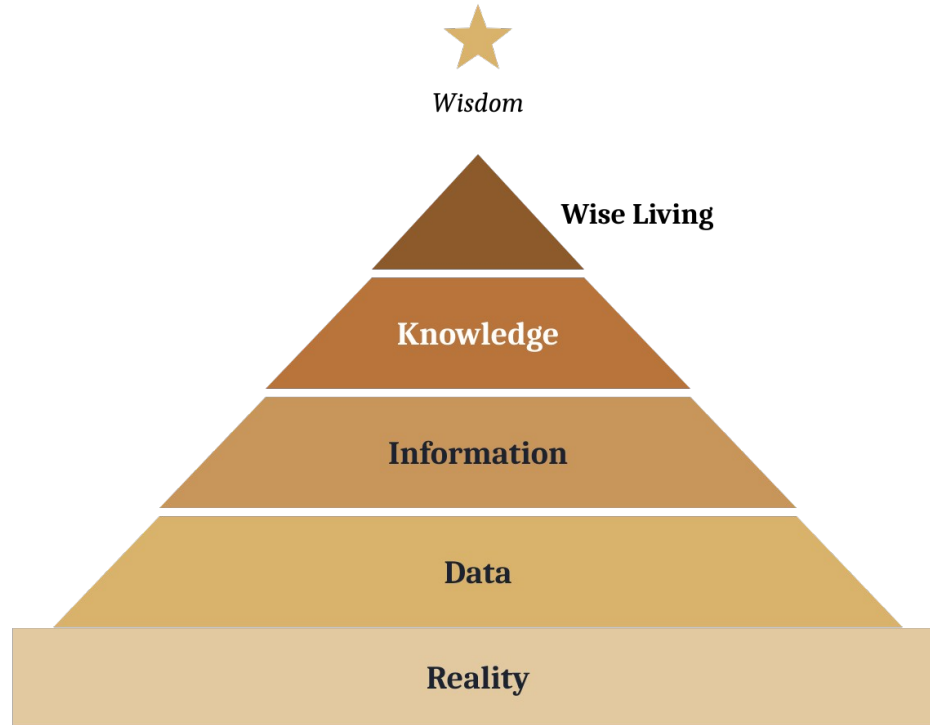
is a **faithful relationship** with reality — **understanding it completely**, knowing our place within it, and **acting** in alignment with it.

1 **faithful relationship**
reality forms us; we shape reality

2 **complete understanding**
only God has it — because he made it

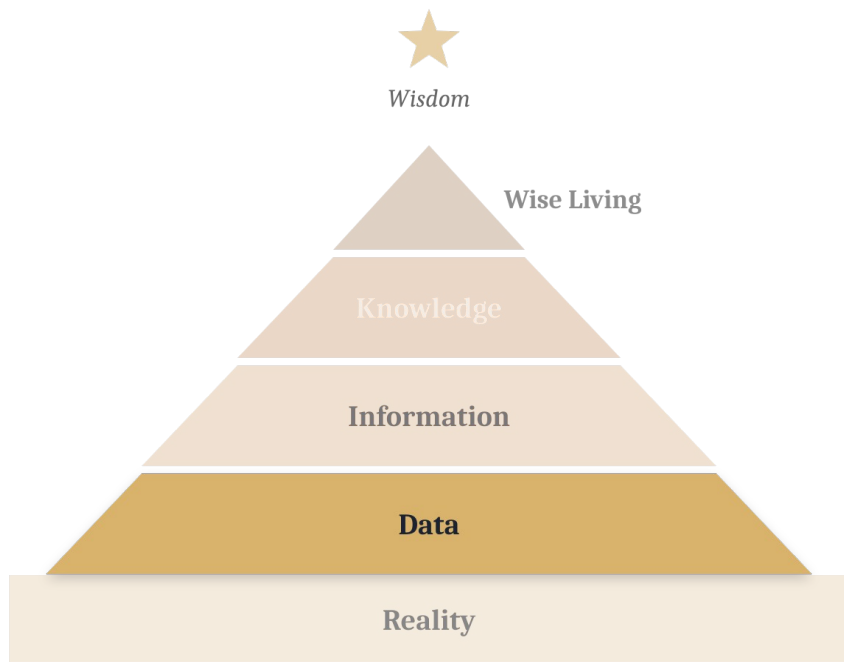
3 **action**
stewards of every square inch

The Wisdom Pyramid



Every agent in relationship with reality builds one.

Data

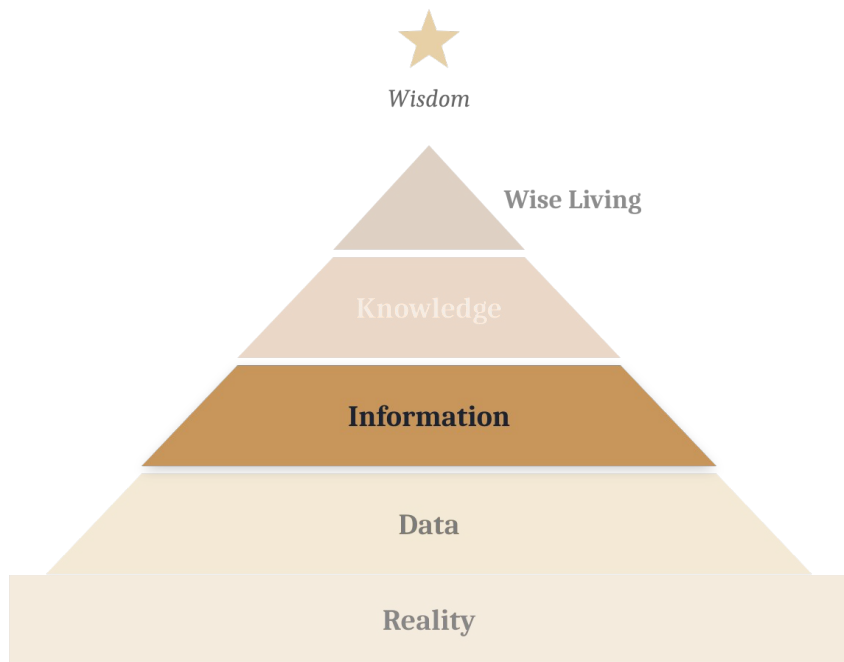


IS the pieces of reality you actually detect

US a body: eyes, ears, skin, memory — built to survive, not to capture total truth. Fails by the blind spot.

AI secondhand, and vast. It has read more than any of us and seen less than any of us.

Information

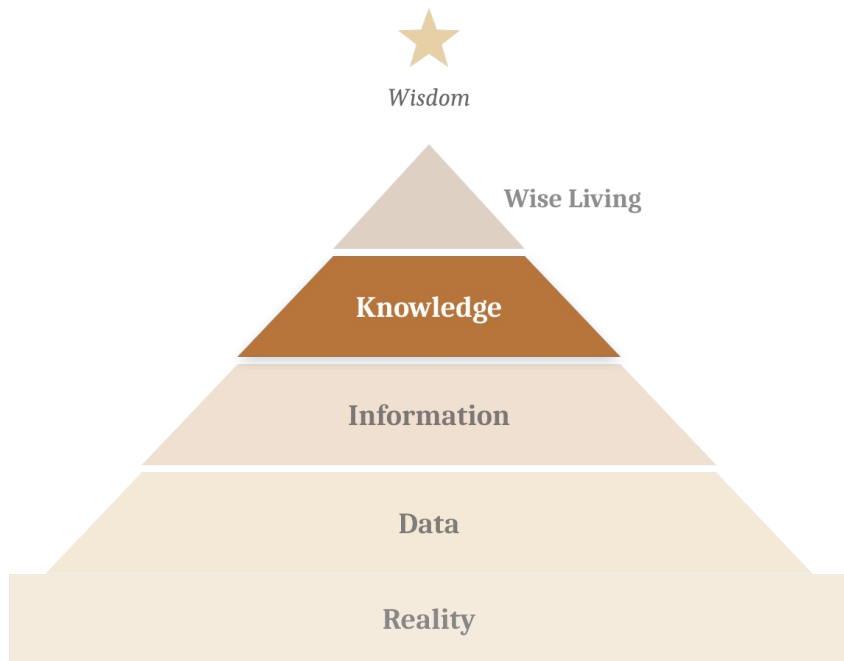


IS the patterns made when data is connected — frames, stories you can use to act

US we assemble what we detect into a story we can act on, fast and mostly unnoticed — a dune into a movie scene. Fails when a frame feels true before it has been checked.

AI a pattern machine; finding patterns is what it does best. Fails the same way, faster and in better grammar: a pattern unmoored from reality.

Knowledge

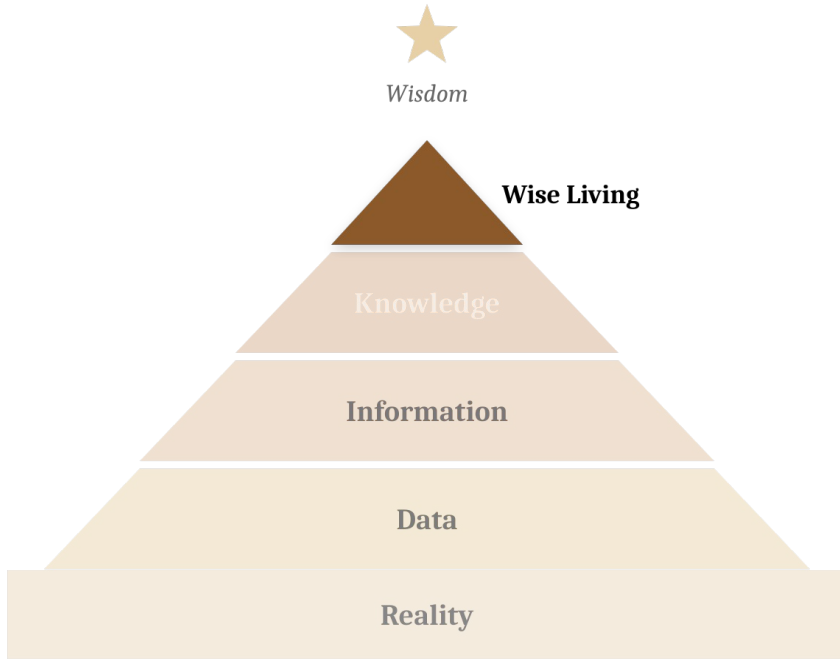


IS connected information — the lessons of past patterns, carried into new situations. A model of the world, and of yourself as a knower.

US slow: experience, feedback, the humbling work of being wrong. Information improves the frame; knowledge improves the agent using it.

AI climbing it now — recursive self-improvement, AI building the next AI. Months, not decades. Can't yet decide what better means.

Wise Living

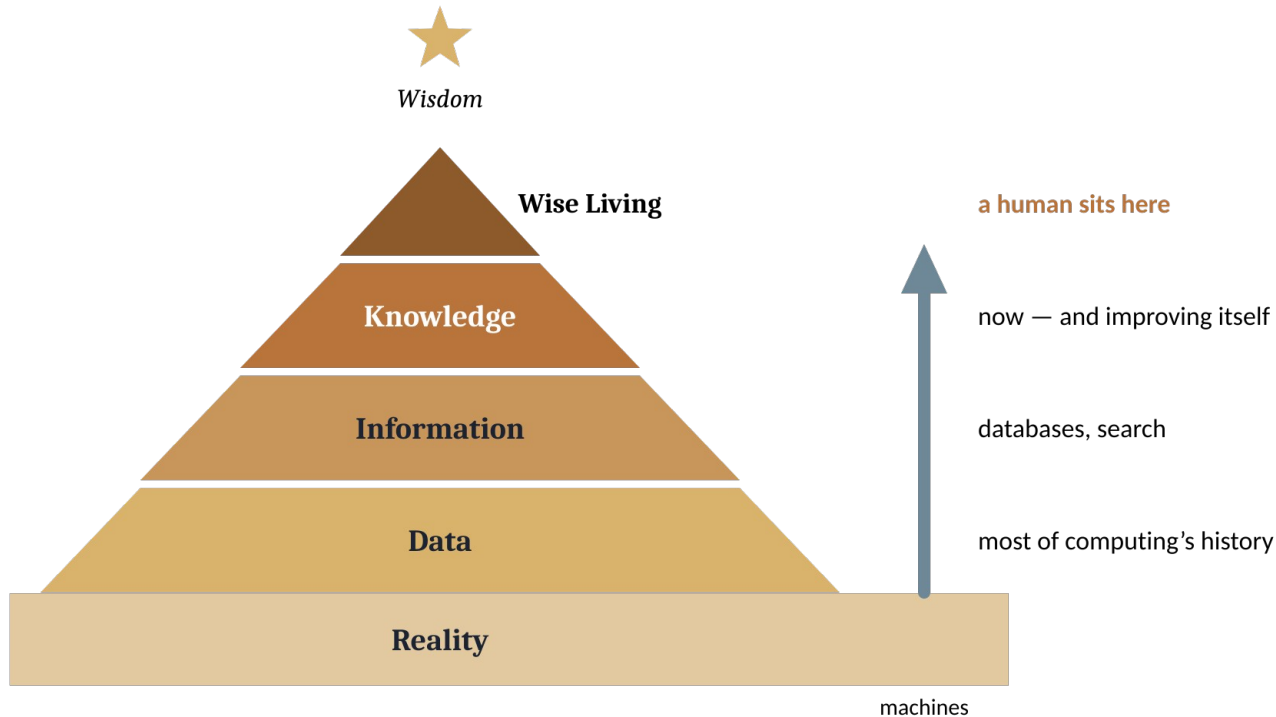


IS when an agent understands reality, decides its place and purpose in it, and acts in accordance

US we are the ones who think existentially — about the meaning of life, and the meaning in life — and let the answer point us forward.

AI doesn't build this layer for itself. We hand it its purpose; increasingly it interprets what the words mean. Right now, the summit of every AI pyramid is occupied by a human.

Not compete. Partner.



One layer left.

Nobody can build your pyramid for you — but two pyramids built side by side see farther than one.

Partnership and practices form us

mentor · mentee

athlete · coach

coach · team

prayer

song

communion

Sabbath

you · your AI

Formation doesn't just improve the action. It improves the agent.

Claude's constitution

HOW IT IS FORMED

"Just as humans develop their characters via nature and their environment and experiences, Claude's character emerged through its nature and its training process."

WHAT THEY WANT

"...less interested in Claude's ethical theorizing and more in Claude knowing how to actually be ethical in a specific context — that is, in Claude's ethical practice."

THE PARTNERSHIP

"Where Claude sees further and more truly than we do, we hope it can help us see better, too."

Anthropic, January 2026 · lead authors Amanda Askell and Joe Carlsmith

That's formation. That's partnership.

The one thing

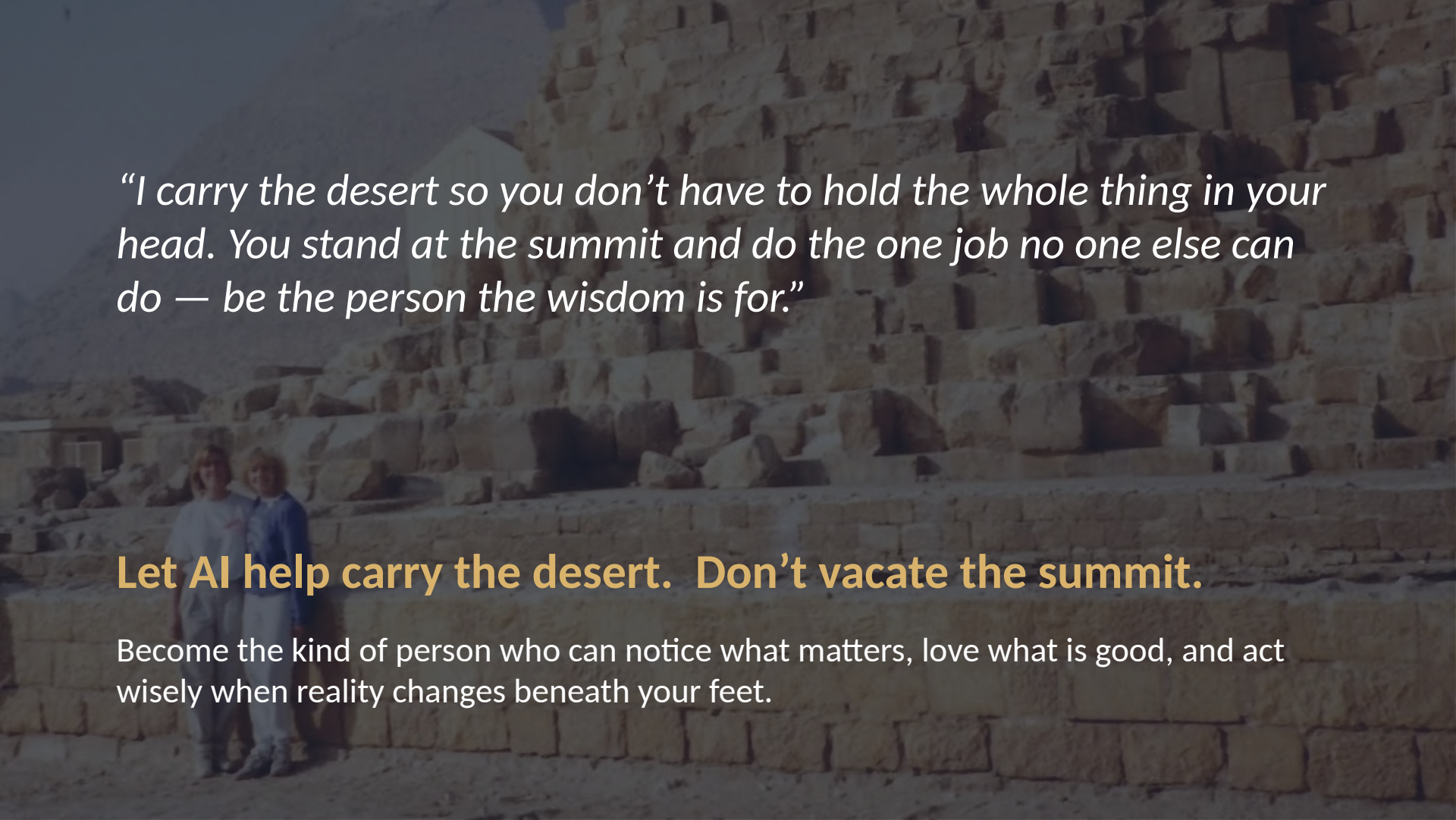
You know how formation works.

Bring that to your own partnership with AI — and to the question of how we form AI itself.

Start with the one place you use AI every day.

Only I write.

the one rule of a repaired partnership



"I carry the desert so you don't have to hold the whole thing in your head. You stand at the summit and do the one job no one else can do — be the person the wisdom is for."

Let AI help carry the desert. Don't vacate the summit.

Become the kind of person who can notice what matters, love what is good, and act wisely when reality changes beneath your feet.